CHATBOT REVIEW · ZOHO SALESIQ

Zoho's chatbot options, *and why they fall short for us.*

In the last plan I said we would try Zoho SalesIQ first, since it already comes with our CRM Plus plan. Before setting up a test page, I went through every way SalesIQ lets us put a chatbot on the website. This note explains each one in simple words: what it is, how it works, and where it falls short of what we need.

PREPARED FOR **DATASPHERE EDU SOLUTIONS** PREPARED BY **VENKATESH BIRADAR** DATE **12 OCT 2026**

WHAT WE NEED	WHAT ZOHO OFFERS	THE SHORT ANSWER
A bot that answers course questions correctly, suggests the right course, and saves every interested student as a lead in Zoho CRM.	Three ways to build a bot in SalesIQ: a flow builder (Zobot), a FAQ bot (Answer Bot), and Zobot with SalesIQ Scripts.	Each one covers part of the job, but none can talk to a student and suggest courses. Zoho CRM stays; the bot should be ours.

01

What we need from the chatbot

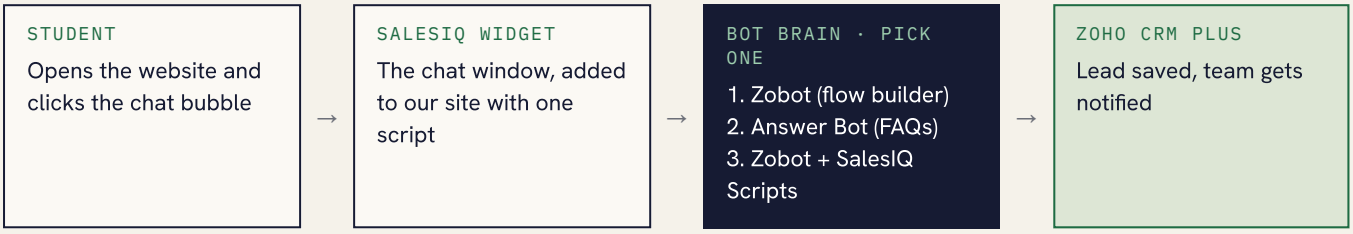
These are the points from the fit check in the last plan, plus one I've added: suggesting courses. That is the main reason we want a chatbot and not just an enquiry form, because most visitors don't know which course they need.

NEED	WHAT IT MEANS	WHY IT MATTERS
Correct course answers	Fees, duration, syllabus, batch timings, online or classroom, placement help.	A wrong fee or date loses a student's trust fast.
Suggests courses ADDED	Asks about the student's background and goal, then points to 1–3 courses.	This is what turns a visitor into an enquiry.
Easy to update	When a batch date or fee changes, the bot picks it up.	The team should be able to do it without me.
Saves leads	Name, phone and course reach Zoho CRM with source "Website – chatbot".	This is how the team follows up.
Hands over to a person	Offers a call-back or our number when it can't answer.	No dead ends for the student.

02

How Zoho puts a chatbot on the website

All of Zoho's options work through **SalesIQ**. We paste one small script on the website and a chat bubble appears in the corner. What changes between the options is the "brain" behind that bubble, meaning how the bot decides what to reply.



When I checked our SalesIQ account, the Bot settings show **Zobot** and **Answer Bot**. Zobot currently says "No bots found", so whichever option we choose starts from zero. There is nothing old to break.

How I've judged each option

For every option, I've gone through the needs from section 01 and marked each one:

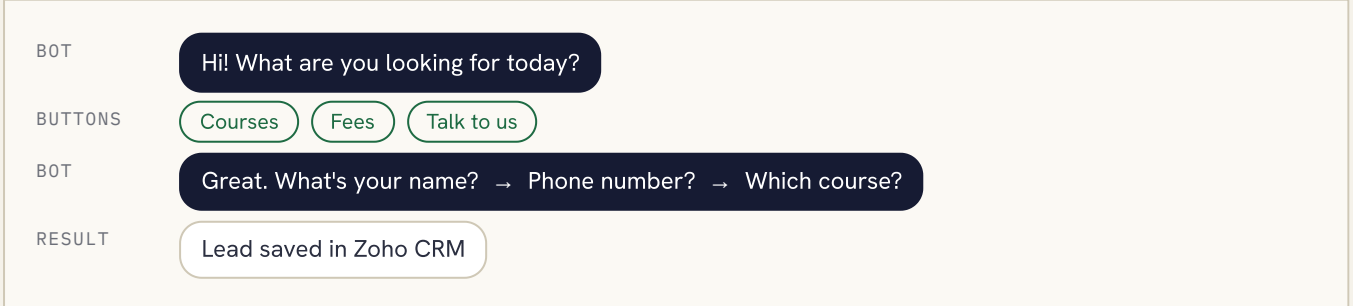
MARK	MEANING
FITS	It does this well, out of the box.
PARTLY	It can do this, but with real limits or a lot of manual work.
DOESN'T FIT	It can't do this in a way we could rely on.

> This review is based on Zoho's SalesIQ help pages and what I saw in our own SalesIQ account. I haven't run the full 25–30 question test yet; the marks below come from how each option is built to work.

03 · Option 1

Zobot: the no-code flow builder

What it is. A drag-and-drop builder where we draw the conversation as a flowchart: greet, ask the name, ask the phone number, show course buttons, then save the lead.



03 · Option 1 — continued

How it works

- The student mostly **clicks buttons**. The bot follows exactly the path we drew, step by step.
- Each answer can be saved into a Zoho CRM field, so lead capture is built in.
- It can pass the chat to a team member, or show our number outside office hours.

Where it falls short

NEED	RESULT	WHY
Correct answers	DOESN'T FIT	It only knows the text we typed into each step. If a student types a question in their own words, it can't understand it.
Suggests courses	DOESN'T FIT	We'd have to draw a separate branch for every mix of background, skill and goal. With all our courses, that becomes a maze nobody can maintain.
Easy to update	PARTLY	Fees and dates live inside the flowchart blocks, so every change means finding and editing the right blocks by hand.
Saves leads	FITS	This is what it does best.
Hands over	FITS	Can route to live chat or show our number.

> **Example.** A student types: *"I'm in 3rd year ECE and know a bit of Python. What should I do for a data job?"* The flow bot can't read this. It can only show its menu buttons again.

04 · Option 2

Answer Bot: replies from our FAQs

What it is. Zoho's ready-made FAQ bot. We add FAQs, articles or web pages to SalesIQ, and when a student asks something, it finds the closest one and replies with it. Newer versions use Zoho's AI (Zia) to reword the answer so it reads naturally.



04 · Option 2 — continued

Where it falls short

NEED	RESULT	WHY
Correct answers	PARTLY	Good for direct questions when one article has the answer. Weaker when the answer is spread across several courses or articles.
Suggests courses	DOESN'T FIT	It answers one question at a time. It doesn't ask follow-up questions about the student or compare courses for them.
Easy to update	PARTLY	All course info has to be rewritten as separate FAQ articles. When a fee or date changes, every article that mentions it must be fixed.
Saves leads	PARTLY	Answering is its job. To collect name and phone, we'd still need a Zobot flow next to it.
Hands over	FITS	Can pass the chat to the team when it has no answer.

GOOD AT	NOT GOOD AT
"What are the batch timings for Data Analytics?"	"Which course should I take first?"
"Is the course online or classroom?"	"I know basic Python and want a job in 6 months. What's my plan?"

05 · Option 3

Zobot with SalesIQ Scripts

What it is. The same Zobot, but instead of drawing a flowchart, we write code in **Deluge**, Zoho's own scripting language. Zoho runs our code every time a student sends a message, and the code decides the reply.

```
// every rule has to be written by hand
if (message.contains("fee")) {
    reply = "The Data Analytics course fee is ...";
} else if (message.contains("python")) {
    reply = "You could start with ...";
} else {
    reply = "Sorry, I didn't get that.";
}
```

A simplified sketch of how a script bot decides replies. It only does what the rules say.

05 · Option 3 — continued

Where it falls short

NEED	RESULT	WHY
Correct answers	PARTLY	Only for questions we've written a rule for. The same question in different words slips through.
Suggests courses	DOESN'T FIT	It isn't AI. We'd be hand-coding a recommendation system out of if/else rules, which would break as soon as a student phrases things their own way.
Easy to update	DOESN'T FIT	Every change needs someone who can edit Deluge code. The team couldn't do it without me.
Saves leads	FITS	Can write straight into Zoho CRM.
Hands over	FITS	Can pass the chat to the team.

> Deluge only runs inside Zoho, so this work can't be reused anywhere else, and testing it is slower than testing normal code.

06

All three, side by side

NEED	ZOBOT (FLOW)	ANSWER BOT	ZOBOT + SCRIPTS
Correct answers	DOESN'T FIT	PARTLY	PARTLY
Suggests courses	DOESN'T FIT	DOESN'T FIT	DOESN'T FIT
Easy to update	PARTLY	PARTLY	DOESN'T FIT
Saves leads	FITS	PARTLY	FITS
Hands over	FITS	FITS	FITS

The pattern is clear: Zoho's bots are good at **collecting details and passing chats to the team**, but none of them can **understand a student and suggest courses**, which is the part we care about most.

What SalesIQ still does well

- It's included in our CRM Plus plan, and its leads land straight in Zoho CRM.
- It also connects to WhatsApp, Instagram and Messenger, where most of our leads come from. Real advantages, but they don't make up for the missing course advice.

07

What I suggest

Go with **Option B** from the earlier proposal: a custom chatbot built on our own course content (RAG + an AI model). It reads our course details, talks to the student in normal language, suggests courses, and sends every interested student to **Zoho CRM** as a lead.

STUDENT
Asks in their own words

→

OUR BOT
Looks up our course info, then the AI writes the answer and suggests courses

→

ZOHO CRM PLUS
Lead saved as "Website – chatbot"

NEED	OUR BOT (PLANNED)	HOW
Correct answers	FITS	Answers only from our course info. If something isn't there, it says so and offers a call-back.
Suggests courses	FITS	Asks 1–2 questions about background and goal, then suggests 1–3 courses.
Easy to update	FITS	All course info lives in one sheet. The team edits the sheet; the bot uses the new info.
Saves leads	FITS	Sends name, phone and course to Zoho CRM through Zoho's API.
Hands over	FITS	Offers a call-back or our number whenever it can't help.

How we'd get there

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	DECISION
Put all course info in one sheet: fees, dates, syllabus, who it's for	Build the bot on it and test it with the same 25–30 real questions	Connect it to Zoho CRM with source "Website – chatbot"	The team reviews the test results before it goes live

What stays the same: Zoho CRM is still where every lead lands, so the team's follow-up doesn't change.

NEXT STEP

Share this with the team. If everyone agrees, I start with step 1: collecting all course info into one sheet.

RELATED DOCUMENTS

DataSphere – How We Will Proceed (section 04, the SalesIQ fit check) and DataSphere – Website Rebuild Plan, Draft v1 (section 5).

Sources: Zoho SalesIQ help pages (zoho.com/salesiq/help) and our own SalesIQ account settings. Zoho adds features often, so I'll recheck before we finalise.